My AI Workforce

PRACTICAL AI GUIDE

Automate Your Customer Support in 3 Steps

⏱ 2–3 hours 📊 Intermediate

Tools covered: OpenClaw or Make/n8n, Zendesk or email

Why Automate Customer Support?

The average SMB spends 15–20 hours per week on repetitive support queries. The same 10–15 questions account for 70–80% of all tickets. Automate those, and you've freed up most of your support workload.

This guide walks you through a simple 3-step framework you can implement today.

Step 1: Map Your Top 10 Support Queries

Before building anything, spend 30 minutes categorising your last 100 support emails or tickets.

How to do it:

1. Export your support inbox to a spreadsheet (Gmail → Export, or Zendesk → Reports)
2. Read through and assign a category to each ticket
3. Count the categories — your top 10 will cover the majority

Common categories for small businesses:

- "How do I reset my password?"
- "Where is my order?"
- "Can I get a refund?"
- "How do I cancel my subscription?"
- "Do you support [platform/feature]?"
- "What are your prices?"
- "How do I get started?"
- "I'm having trouble logging in"
- "Can I speak to someone?"
- "Do you have a free trial?"

Write out a clear, complete answer for each. This becomes your response template library.

Step 2: Create Response Templates

For each of your top queries, write a template with these components:

Structure:

```
[Personalised greeting]
[Direct answer to their question]
[Next step or link to help them further]
[Warm sign-off]
```

Example — Refund Request:

```
Hi [Name],

Thanks for reaching out. I can help with that.

We offer full refunds within 30 days of purchase, no questions asked.
To process yours, I just need your order number — you'll find it in
your original confirmation email.

Once you reply with that, I'll action the refund within 1 business day.

[Your name]
```

Store these in a simple document or directly in your support tool as macros/snippets.

Step 3: Set Up Routing Rules

Now connect your templates to an automated triage system.

Option A: OpenClaw (AI-powered)

Add to your `HEARTBEAT.md`:

```
## Support Inbox Check (every 15 minutes)
1. Check the support@yourdomain.com inbox
2. For each new email:
   - If it matches a known query type, draft a response using the template
   - If it's complex or requires human judgment, flag with label "NEEDS-HUMAN"
   - If it's spam/irrelevant, archive it
3. Report: X emails processed, Y flagged for human review
```

In your `SOUL.md`, add a support section:

```
## Customer Support Rules
- Always acknowledge the customer's frustration before solving
- Never promise refunds or exceptions without checking with the human
- For billing issues, always flag for human review — no exceptions
- Response time goal: within 2 hours for all standard queries
```

Option B: Zendesk Triggers (No-code)

1. Go to **Admin → Objects & Rules → Triggers**
2. Create a trigger: **Conditions:** Ticket is created + Subject contains "refund"
3. **Actions:** Assign to group "Billing" + Send email using macro "Refund Template"

Repeat for each of your top query types.

Option C: Make/Zapier (Workflow automation)

1. Trigger: New email in support inbox
2. Action: Pass subject + body to AI (GPT-4 or Claude)
3. Prompt: "Classify this support email into one of these categories: [list]. Return category name only."
4. Router: Branch based on category → Send matching template

Connecting to Multiple Channels

If customers contact you via multiple channels (email, live chat, social), consider a unified inbox tool:

- **Freshdesk** — Free tier, supports email + social
- **Intercom** — Chat + email, AI-powered
- **Crisp** — Good free tier for small teams

These tools let you apply your template library across all channels from one place.

Measuring Success

Track these metrics weekly:

- **First Response Time** — Target: under 2 hours
- **Resolution Rate** — % of tickets solved without escalation
- **Customer Satisfaction** — CSAT score (most tools have built-in surveys)
- **Ticket Volume** — Should drop as your FAQ page improves

What's Next?

- Build a public FAQ page to deflect tickets before they arrive
- Train a chatbot on your top 20 Q&A pairs for instant responses

- Set up a knowledge base with Notion or Gitbook

For pre-built support agents, browse the My AI Workforce Marketplace